MODULE 3

THE LANGUAGE OF A DEBATER

Learning Goals

- Use **clear and confident language** during a debate.
- Learn useful **opening, linking, agreeing, disagreeing, and concluding phrases**.
- Use **formal but natural** language instead of casual expressions.
- Learn how to **introduce and explain a point** smoothly.
- Use **signposting words** to help the audience follow your speech.
- Express **disagreement respectfully**.
- Use **persuasive language** without becoming aggressive.
- Build a personal **debate phrase bank** for speaking practice.

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1. Why Language Matters in Debate

A strong argument becomes more effective when it is expressed in **clear, organised, and confident language**. Good debaters help the audience understand not only **what** they believe, but also **how** their ideas connect.

Clear: Use simple and precise language.

Organised: Connect your ideas logically.

Confident: Speak clearly and avoid unnecessary hesitation.

Respectful: Challenge ideas without attacking people.

Your goal is not to use difficult English. Your goal is to use effective English.

2. Starting Your Speech

The first few sentences of a debate speech should tell the audience **who you are, which side you support, and what your main idea is**.

Useful Opening Phrases

- **Good morning everyone.** Today, I am speaking **in favour of** this motion.
- **I strongly support** the motion that…
- **I respectfully oppose** the motion that…
- **Our team believes that**…
- **Today, I would like to explain why**…

Example: “Good morning everyone. I am speaking in favour of the motion that students should read every day. I will explain how regular reading can improve vocabulary, understanding, and creativity.”

3. Introducing Your First Point

After your introduction, make your first argument easy to identify. This is called **signposting** — telling the audience where your speech is going.

Useful Phrases

- **My first point is that…**
- **Let us begin with…**
- **The first reason is…**
- **One important point is…**
- **To begin with,…**
- **Firstly,…**

Then state your claim, give your reason, and support it with an example or evidence.

4. Connecting Your Ideas

A good debate speech should not sound like a list of separate sentences. Use **linking words and phrases** to show how your ideas connect.

Purpose	Useful Language
Add an idea	**Furthermore, In addition, Also, Moreover**
Show sequence	**Firstly, Secondly, Finally**
Give an example	**For example, For instance**
Show a result	**Therefore, As a result, Consequently**
Show contrast	**However, On the other hand, In contrast**
Explain	**This is because, This means that**
Emphasise	**Most importantly, It is important to note that**

> **Example: Firstly, regular reading improves vocabulary. In addition, it can improve understanding. Most importantly, it can help students become more confident readers.**

5. Giving Reasons Clearly

A debater should make the connection between a **claim** and a **reason** easy to understand.

Useful Phrases

- **This is because…**
- **The main reason is that…**
- **One reason for this is…**
- **This happens because…**
- **The reason I say this is…**
- **This matters because…**

Example: Students should have regular sports periods. **This is because** physical activity helps them stay active and gives them a break from sitting for long periods.

> **Stronger version: Students should have regular sports periods. The main reason is that physical activity supports an active lifestyle. This matters because students spend a large part of their day sitting and studying.**

6. Giving Examples and Evidence

Examples help the audience **see your argument in a real situation**.

Useful Example Phrases

- **For example,…**
- **For instance,…**

- **A simple example is…**
- **We can see this when…**
- **Consider the example of…**
- **This can be seen in…**

Introducing Evidence

- **According to…**
- **Research shows that…**
- **Evidence suggests that…**
- **A recent study found that…**
- **Data shows that…**

> **Important:** Only use facts and statistics when you are confident they are accurate and from a reliable source.
>
> **Never invent evidence.**

7. Agreeing with a Point

Debates are not always about completely rejecting the other side. Sometimes you can **recognise a valid point** and then explain your own position.

Useful Phrases

- **I agree that…**
- **I agree with the point that…**
- **That is a fair point.**
- **I understand that argument.**
- **There is some truth in that.**
- **I accept that…**

> **Example: I agree that mobile phones can sometimes support learning. However, they can also become a distraction when students use them during lessons.**

8. Disagreeing Respectfully

A good debater can disagree **without being rude**. Avoid personal attacks. Challenge the **idea**, not the person.

Avoid	Use Instead
“You are stupid.”	**I respectfully disagree.**
“That is a ridiculous idea.”	**I understand your point, but…**
“You don't know anything.”	**I see it differently because…**

Avoid	Use Instead
“You are wrong.”	**I would like to challenge that point.**

More useful phrases:

- **That argument may sound reasonable, but…**
- **I do not fully agree with that view.**
- **There is another way to look at this.**

9. Introducing a Different Perspective

Strong debaters show that they understand **more than one perspective**.

- **From another perspective,…**
- **On the other hand,…**
- **Another way to look at this is…**
- **Some people may argue that…**
- **The opposing side may say that…**
- **It is also possible to argue that…**

Example: Some people may argue that homework helps students practise what they learn in class. **However**, too much homework may reduce time for sleep and other activities.

10. Responding to the Other Side

When the opposing team gives an argument, do not simply say **“No.”** First, identify their point. Then respond to it.

Recognise → Respond → Support

Recognise: “The opposing team argues that homework improves discipline.”

Respond: “However, discipline does not necessarily depend on a large amount of homework.”

Support: “For example, students can develop responsibility through projects, reading, sports, and classroom activities.”

Useful Phrases

- **The opposing side argues that…**
- **They have suggested that…**
- **However, this does not necessarily mean that…**
- **This argument overlooks…**
- **The problem with this argument is…**
- **A more important point is…**

11. Persuasive Language

Debaters often need to make their ideas **strong and convincing**. Persuasive language helps the audience understand why your point deserves attention.

- **It is important to…**
- **We must consider…**
- **We should recognise…**
- **There is a clear need to…**
- **This can have a significant impact on…**
- **This can benefit…**
- **This can lead to…**
- **This is essential because…**

> **Example: We must consider the amount of time students spend sitting every day. Regular physical activity can have a significant impact on their overall well-being.**

Avoid overstatement: Instead of "This will definitely solve every problem," say "This can help reduce the problem."

12. Asking Rhetorical Questions

A **rhetorical question** is a question asked to make the audience think. You do not necessarily expect an answer.

> **"If education is important, shouldn't every student have access to quality learning?"**
>
> **"How can students stay healthy if they never have time for physical activity?"**
>
> **"If reading improves knowledge, why should we discourage students from reading?"**

Useful Starters

- **How can we…?**
- **Why should we…?**
- **Can we really say that…?**
- **Is it fair to…?**
- **What happens when…?**

> **Use rhetorical questions carefully. One strong question can be more effective than many questions.**

13. Emphasising Important Points

Sometimes you want the audience to remember one particular idea.

- **The most important point is…**
- **What we must remember is…**

- **Let me emphasise that…**
- **This is especially important because…**
- **Above all,…**
- **Most importantly,…**

> **Example: Most importantly, education should help students develop both knowledge and practical skills.**

14. Moving from One Point to Another

Good speakers make their **transitions** clear.

Moving to the next point

- **Moving on to my second point,…**
- **Let us now consider…**
- **My next point is…**
- **Another important issue is…**

Moving to the final point

- **Finally,…**
- **My final point is…**
- **Last but not least,…**
- **Before I conclude,…**

> **Example: Moving on to my second point, let us consider the effect of reading on vocabulary.**

15. Concluding Your Speech

A strong conclusion should **remind the audience of your position and main ideas**. Do not introduce a completely new argument in your conclusion.

Useful Closing Phrases

- **To conclude,…**
- **In conclusion,…**
- **To sum up,…**
- **In summary,…**
- **For these reasons,…**
- **Taking all these points into consideration,…**

Strong Final Lines

- **For these reasons, I strongly support the motion.**
- **For these reasons, I respectfully oppose the motion.**
- **That is why we believe this motion should be supported.**

Example: To conclude, regular reading can improve vocabulary, understanding, and creativity. For these reasons, I strongly support the motion that students should read every day.

16. Debate Language: Formal vs. Casual

In a debate, try to use **clear and reasonably formal language**. Formal does not mean complicated. **Simple, accurate English is powerful.**

Casual	Better for Debate
I think…	**I believe…**
You are wrong.	**I respectfully disagree.**
That's not true.	**I do not agree with that claim.**
It's a bad idea.	**There are several concerns with this idea.**
You know…	**It is important to note that…**
A lot of…	**A large number of…**
Kids	**Children / Students**
Stuff	**Issues / Things / Materials**
Really good	**Highly beneficial / Effective**
Really bad	**Harmful / Problematic**

17. Building Your Debate Phrase Bank

Create your own personal list of useful debate expressions.

Opening: _____

Introducing a point: _____

Giving a reason: _____

Giving an example: _____

Agreeing: _____

Disagreeing: _____

Responding to the other side: _____

Adding a point: _____

Concluding: _____

Tip: Choose phrases that feel natural to you and practise saying them aloud.

18. Language Practice

Complete each sentence with a suitable debate phrase.

A. Starting: _____, I strongly support this motion.

B. Giving a reason: This is _____ students need enough time to rest.

C. Giving an example: _____, students can develop communication skills through group activities.

D. Disagreeing: I understand your point, _____ I respectfully disagree.

E. Adding an idea: _____, regular reading can improve vocabulary.

F. Concluding: _____, I believe this motion should be supported.

Challenge: Try to use at least **five different debate phrases** in a 45-second speech.

19. Build a Complete Debate Paragraph

Use the language you have learned to create one complete argument.

Structure:

SIGNPOST → CLAIM → REASON → EXAMPLE → RESULT

Example: Firstly, I believe students should have regular sports periods. This is because physical activity helps students stay active. For example, students can participate in football, cricket, running, or other activities. As a result, they can develop healthier and more active habits.

Your Turn

Signpost: _____

Claim: _____

Reason: _____

Example: _____

Result: _____

20. Challenge — Speak Like a Debater

Choose one motion:

- Students should have less homework.
- Every student should learn a sport.
- Schools should allow more creative activities.
- Students should read for 20 minutes every day.

- School uniforms should be compulsory.

Prepare a 45–60 second speech.

Your speech must include:

- **1. An opening**
- **2. A clear claim**
- **3. A reason**
- **4. An example**
- **5. A linking word**
- **6. A respectful response to another viewpoint**
- **7. A conclusion**

Speaking Checklist

- ■ Did I speak **clearly**?
- ■ Did I use **complete sentences**?
- ■ Did I use at least **three debate phrases**?
- ■ Did I connect my ideas with **linking words**?
- ■ Did I disagree **respectfully**?
- ■ Did I give an **example**?
- ■ Did I finish with a **clear conclusion**?

KEY TAKEAWAY

A good debater does not only have **strong ideas**. A good debater knows **how to express those ideas clearly, confidently, logically, and respectfully**.

INTRODUCE → EXPLAIN → CONNECT → SUPPORT → RESPOND → CONCLUDE

Speak clearly. Think logically. Respectfully challenge ideas.